

PM Announces Fast-Track Courts to Tackle Public Examination Paper Leaks



For Prelims: Fast-Track Courts , National Testing Agency , Right to a speedy trial , Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act, 2024

For Mains: Meritocracy and institutional trust in public examinations, Speedy justice versus systemic governance reforms, Internal security challenges posed by organised examination mafias, Accountability and transparency in public institutions

Source: TH

Why in News?

The Prime Minister of India announced the **establishment of Fast-Track Courts (FTCs)** to ensure swift and stringent punishment for individuals and syndicates involved in public examination paper leaks.

- This policy directive comes in response to the massive nationwide protests over **irregularities in the NEET-UG 2026 examination** .
- Subsequently, the Delhi High Court constituted a **Special Fast-Track Court** to exclusively try offences under the **Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act, 2024** , with **all pending cases under the Act transferred to the new court for speedy disposal** .

Summary

- **The Prime Minister of India announced the establishment of Fast-Track Courts (FTCs)** to ensure **swift investigation and speedy trials** in public examination paper leak cases, aiming to strengthen deterrence and restore public confidence in the integrity of competitive examinations.
- **While FTCs provide timely judicial remedies, preventing paper leaks requires broader institutional reforms** , including strengthening the **National Testing Agency (NTA)** , implementing the **Dr. K. Radhakrishnan Committee (2024)** recommendations, adopting secure digital technologies, and enhancing accountability.

What are Fast-Track Courts (FTCs)?

- **About:** Fast-Track Courts (FTCs) are specialized judicial mechanisms established to **expedite the trial and disposal of specific, high-priority, or long-pending cases**, thereby reducing the **immense backlog burdening India's regular subordinate judiciary**.
- **Constitutional Backing:** The Supreme Court has repeatedly read the **right to a speedy trial into Article 21** (Right to Life and Personal Liberty) (e.g., *Hussainara Khatoon v. Home Secretary, State of Bihar*, 1979).
- **No Single Central Act:** Unlike regular courts governed strictly by uniform codes of criminal procedure, there is **no single central legislation that universally establishes or governs all fast-track courts**.
 - Instead, they are created through periodic **finance commission recommendations**, specific central schemes, or high court notifications.
- **Targeted Categories of Cases:**
 - **Heinous Crimes & Long-Pending Disputes:** The **Eleventh Finance Commission (2000-2005)** first recommended the establishment of **Fast Track Courts (FTCs)** to expedite the disposal of **long-pending Sessions and other criminal cases**.
 - Subsequently, the **Fourteenth Finance Commission (2015-2020)** expanded their scope by recommending FTCs for **heinous crimes** such as **murder, kidnapping, and extortion**, as well as **civil property disputes pending for over five years** and cases involving **vulnerable groups**.
 - **Vulnerable Demographics:** They prioritize cases involving vulnerable groups, including women, children, senior citizens, persons with disabilities, and terminally ill individuals.
 - **Fast-Track Special Courts (FTSCs):** FTSCs are **dedicated courts** established under a **Centrally Sponsored Scheme (CSS)** in **October 2019** to ensure the **speedy trial and disposal** of cases related to **rape** and offences under the **Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act, 2012**.
 - The scheme was launched following the **Criminal Law (Amendment) Act, 2018** and the **Supreme Court's Suo Motu Writ (Criminal) No. 1 of 2019**. **Partially funded through the Nirbhaya Fund**, the scheme includes **Exclusive POCSO (e-POCSO) Courts**, which exclusively handle cases involving child sexual abuse under the POCSO Act.
 - In 2017, the Supreme Court of India directed the central government to set up **special fast-track courts to speed up criminal trials against Members of Parliament (MPs) and Members of Legislative Assembly (MLAs)**, aiming to clean up politics.
- **Constitutional Scrutiny:** Under the touchstone of equality before law (Article 14), the Supreme Court (notably in *State of West Bengal vs Anwar Ali Sarkar*, 1952) ruled that **"speed" alone cannot be an arbitrary criterion to pick individual cases**.
 - Special or fast-track classification must **rest on a rational, objective basis, such as the grave nature of the offense or victim vulnerability**.
- **Efficiency vs. Structural Challenges:** While regular trial courts **clear roughly 3.3 cases per month**, FTSCs operate at a higher efficiency, **disposing of an average of about 9.5 cases per month**.
 - Despite these high clearance rates, the large volume of cases continues to pose a challenge, with over 2.4 lakh cases still pending before Fast Track Special Courts (FTSCs) by the end of 2023.
- **Landmark Judicial Precedents Governing FTCs:**
 - **Brij Mohan Lal v. Union of India (2012):** The Supreme Court held that the continuation and establishment of Fast Track Courts (FTCs) is primarily the responsibility of the States.
 - It further observed that **ad hoc courts and temporary judicial appointments cannot be a**

permanent solution to judicial delays, emphasizing the need for regular judicial infrastructure, adequate staffing, and timely appointments to strengthen the justice delivery system.

- **Anita Kushwaha v. Pushap Sudan (2016):** The Supreme Court held that **access to justice is a Fundamental Right under Articles 14 and 21**, underscoring the need for adequate judicial infrastructure and timely justice.
- **P. Ramachandra Rao v. State of Karnataka (2002)** : The **Supreme Court** held that **no fixed time limit can be prescribed for concluding criminal trials**, as it is neither feasible nor judicially permissible.

Significance of FTCs in Public Examination Paper Leak Cases

- **Restoring Institutional Trust:** Speedy disposal of paper leak cases reinforces **meritocracy** and restores the **confidence of millions of aspirants** in the fairness and credibility of public examinations.
- **Strengthening Deterrence:** Swift investigation and timely punishment increase the **certainty of punishment**, discouraging organised examination fraud and paper leak networks.
- **Protecting India's Demographic Dividend:** Quick resolution of cases reduces repeated exam cancellations, safeguarding the **career prospects, mental well-being, and financial security** of young aspirants while preserving the country's demographic potential.

Click here to Read: [NEET-UG 2026 Paper Leak: Crisis in India's Examination System](#)

What are the Limitations of Fast-Track Courts in Tackling Public Examination Paper Leaks?

- **Post-Facto Remedy:** FTCs provide **speedy adjudication only after a paper leak has occurred**. They cannot prevent leaks or reverse the damage caused through exam cancellations and loss of public trust.
 - Setting up **Fast-Track Courts (FTCs)** alone is insufficient, as their effectiveness varies across case types. While **POCSO** and **IPC** FTCs often struggle with heavy caseloads and judicial vacancies, **Prevention of Corruption Act** courts have performed relatively better due to a more balanced judge-to-case ratio.
- **Inter-State Jurisdiction Challenges:** While the **Delhi High Court** has designated a **Special Fast Track Court** for offences under the **Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act, 2024**, **education falls under the Concurrent List (Entry 25)** and paper leak syndicates often operate across State boundaries.
 - **Localised FTCs** may not effectively address crimes without coordinated national investigations.
 - **Without a nationwide network of FTCs and a central nodal investigation mechanism**, localised courts may struggle to effectively tackle organised, inter-state examination fraud.
- **Digital Forensics Bottleneck:** Modern paper leaks involve **encrypted messaging apps, the dark web**, **IP logs, and crypto transactions**.
 - Delays in **Forensic Science Laboratory (FSL)** reports and **cyber-forensic investigations**, caused by **limited operational forensic capacity**, often slow trials and undermine the objective of defeating the purpose of fast-tracking.
 - Judicial officers presiding over FTCs require specialized technical assistance and domain expertise to evaluate digital forensics, which local police often fail to provide.

- **Investigation-Trial Gap:** FTCs can function only **after a charge sheet is filed** . Multi-state investigations involving **State Police, Cyber Cells, CBI, ED, and financial tracing** often take months or years, limiting the impact of speedy trials.
 - Delays in investigation may result in default bail, defeating the objective of speedy trials. For instance, an accused in the NEET-UG 2024 paper leak case, was granted default bail after the **CBI** failed to file the chargesheet within the statutory 90-day period.
 - Pressure for speedy disposal may result in the conviction of **lower-level intermediaries** , while masterminds behind organised paper leak syndicates evade prosecution due to incomplete financial and digital evidence.
- **Structural Deficiencies:** As highlighted in ***Brij Mohan Lal v. Union of India (2012)*** , FTCs often suffer from **ad hoc funding, inadequate infrastructure, shortage of judges, prosecutors, and support staff** , reducing their long-term effectiveness.
 - Speedy trials require an ecosystem including dedicated Special Public Prosecutors (SPPs), specialized cyber/forensic units, and prompt summons execution. FTCs lack this dedicated support matrix.
- **Funding Friction:** With the end of the initial central grant, funding FTCs became the responsibility of State governments.
 - Uneven financial health across states leads to vast disparities in FTC performance (e.g., **UP and Maharashtra have functional FTSCs, while several other states have dismantled them**).
- **Witness & Prosecution Challenges:** Weak **witness protection** , intimidation by organised exam mafias, alleged political connections and the absence of dedicated cyber-experts can weaken prosecution and reduce conviction rates.

Addressing Institutional Gaps in Public Examinations: The Dr. K. Radhakrishnan Committee Reforms

- While Fast-Track Courts (FTCs) provide a post-facto judicial remedy by ensuring speedy trials, preventing paper leaks requires systemic administrative and technological reforms.
- In this regard, the recommendations of the **Dr. K. Radhakrishnan High-Level Committee (2024)** provides a roadmap to address the structural vulnerabilities in the examination system, many of which still await effective implementation.

Reform Area	Operational Gap	Dr. K. Radhakrishnan Committee Recommendation (2024)
Examination Format	Single-day OMR-based examinations (e.g., NEET) remain vulnerable, where a single paper leak can compromise the entire examination.	Shift to multi-shift Computer-Based Tests (CBTs) to localize and contain the impact of any potential breach.
Examination Logistics	Continued reliance on third-party vendors for question paper printing and physical transportation creates vulnerabilities in the examination chain.	Minimize or eliminate outsourcing of sensitive logistics , ensuring secure end-to-end handling by authorized agencies.
Candidate Identity Verification	Partial implementation of biometric verification, while impersonation techniques continue to evolve.	Implement DIGI-EXAM , a DigiYatra-inspired biometric identity layer linking candidate authentication from application to admission.

Way Forward

- **Strengthen NTA:** Convert the **National Testing Agency (NTA)** into an autonomous statutory body with independent funding, functional autonomy, and accountability, on the lines of the **Union Public Service Commission (UPSC)**, to ensure the integrity and credibility of national-level examinations.
 - Conduct high-stakes examinations only in controlled, high-security centres under direct state supervision to minimize the risk of paper leaks.
- **Dedicated Investigation SOP:** A Supreme Court-monitored Standard Operating Procedure (SOP) is required for time-bound investigations by specialized cyber-cells (like CERT-In) to submit charge sheets directly to the FTCs within a 90-day window.
- **Technological Fortification:** Implementing **Quantum Key Distribution (QKD)** for the digital transmission of question papers and utilizing blockchain-based audit trails to ensure the **absolute immutability of examination data from creation to deployment**.
- **Zero-Tolerance** : Mandate a "Command-Failure Liability Clause" under the Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act, 2024, to fix accountability on supervisory officials for lapses in examination security.

Conclusion

Public examinations are the bedrock of India's demographic dividend and the constitutional promise of equal opportunity. While Fast-Track Courts deliver timely **retributive justice**, true accountability **requires systemic administrative ethics transitioning from reactive punishment to preventive, tamper-proof state responsibility**.

Drishti Mains Question:

Fast-Track Courts can ensure speedy justice but cannot substitute systemic reforms in preventing public examination paper leaks. Discuss.

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

1. What are Fast-Track Courts (FTCs)?

FTCs are **specialized courts** established to ensure the **speedy trial and disposal** of priority and long-pending cases, thereby reducing judicial delays.

2. What is the Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act, 2024?

It is a law enacted to **prevent and penalize unfair practices** such as paper leaks and organized cheating in **public examinations**, prescribing stringent punishments for offenders.

3. What are the major limitations of Fast-Track Courts in tackling paper leak cases?

FTCs provide only a **post-facto remedy** and are constrained by **investigation delays, digital forensic bottlenecks, inter-state jurisdiction issues, and inadequate judicial infrastructure**.

4. What are the key recommendations of the Dr. K. Radhakrishnan Committee (2024)?

The Committee recommended **multi-shift CBTs, secure government-controlled examination logistics, and DIGI-EXAM biometric identity verification** to strengthen examination security.

5. What measures can strengthen the integrity of public examinations in India?

Key measures include **making the NTA a statutory body, adopting secure digital technologies, establishing time-bound investigations, and strengthening accountability through a Command-Failure Liability Clause**.

[Watch Video on YouTube:

▶ <https://www.youtube.com/embed/230kG3b4xlc>]

UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year Question (PYQ)

Prelims

Q. Which of the following provisions of the Constitution does India have a bearing on Education? (2012)

1. Directive Principles of State Policy
2. Rural and Urban Local Bodies
3. Fifth Schedule
4. Sixth Schedule
5. Seventh Schedule

Select the correct answer using the codes given below:

- (a) 1 and 2 only
- (b) 3, 4 and 5 only
- (c) 1, 2 and 5 only
- (d) 1, 2, 3, 4 and 5

Ans: D

Mains

Q. How have digital initiatives in India contributed to the functioning of the education system in the country? Elaborate on your answer. **(2020)**

Rome Declaration for an Unarmed and Disarming Peace



For Prelims: Artificial Intelligence , Black box nature of AI , Deep neural networks , Open Skies , New START , Global Partnership on Artificial Intelligence (GPAI) .

For Mains: Ethical and Regulatory Challenges of AI, Humanity and Ethics, Artificial Intelligence: A Tool for Humanity or a Threat to Human Agency

Why in News?

The **Rome Declaration for an Unarmed and Disarming Peace** , signed in **July 2026** by **Nobel laureates, AI scientists, religious leaders, and other global luminaries** , has raised concerns over the "**convergent peril**" arising from the **growing trend of delegating moral and ethical decision-making to Artificial Intelligence (AI) systems** .

Summary

- The **Rome Declaration for an Unarmed and Disarming Peace** warns against the "**convergent peril**" of outsourcing **moral and ethical decision-making** to Artificial Intelligence, particularly in **nuclear command-and-control systems** , and calls for an international treaty mandating **meaningful human control** over autonomous weapons.
- As AI increasingly influences strategic and public decision-making, the focus has shifted towards **ethical, transparent, and human-centric AI governance** , with initiatives such as the **EU AI Act, UNESCO AI Ethics Recommendation, IndiaAI Mission, and MeitY's AI Governance Guidelines** promoting **responsible AI, accountability, and explainability** .

What is the Rome Declaration for an Unarmed and Disarming Peace?

- **About:** The **Rome Declaration for an Unarmed and Disarming Peace** is a strategic and moral appeal to the international community.
 - The Declaration calls for an **international treaty prohibiting autonomous AI systems from accessing or making decisions on nuclear weapon launches** , stressing that **human ethics, accountability, and judgment must never be outsourced to AI** , particularly in matters involving war, peace, and the future of humanity.
- **Philosophical Foundation:** The document is inspired by **Pope Leo XIV's encyclical Magnifica Humanitas**, which serves as a "clarion call" to shield human dignity from technological overreach.
- **Current Status:** Presently, it functions as a normative "nudge" rather than a binding legal framework, as global consensus on regulating autonomous AI in warfare remains absent.
- **Principles of the Rome Declaration:**
 - **Disarming the Next Arms Race** – Prevent an AI-driven military and nuclear arms race.
 - **Responsible Development** – Ensure AI systems are developed within transparent ethical frameworks.
 - **Responsible Use of AI** – Restrict AI from making autonomous decisions in high-risk military domains.
 - **Responsible Governance** – Promote international oversight, regulation, and accountability for AI.
 - **Responsible Leadership** – Encourage governments, industry, and scientific communities to prioritise ethics over technological competition.
 - **Nuclear Disarmament** – Renew global commitment towards complete, irreversible, and verifiable elimination of nuclear weapons.

- **Ethical & Operational Mandates:** To counter the "**black box**" **nature of AI** where reasoning is opaque and relying on it for mass-casualty decisions is the antithesis of scientific responsibility the Declaration puts forth five ethical mandates:
 - **Mandatory Meaningful Human Control:** An absolute prohibition on automated or AI-driven systems making the final decision to deploy nuclear weapons.
 - **The 'Digital Commons' Model:** A push to democratize data so independent experts can better analyze and mitigate the existential threats and unintended consequences of ungoverned AI.
 - **Responsible Development:** AI developers must publish their guiding ethical frameworks. The creation of fully autonomous, self-improving systems that cannot be audited or abruptly halted by humans is explicitly forbidden.
 - **Internal Arsenal Vulnerability Audits:** Nuclear-armed states must urgently conduct rigorous technical reviews to shield their atomic command-and-control networks from AI-driven cyber-tampering.
 - **Time-Bound, Verifiable Disarmament:** A demand to renew good-faith international negotiations to completely, irreversibly, and verifiably eliminate nuclear arsenals.

The Need for the Declaration

- **Compression of Decision-Making Windows:** Historical deterrence such as 'mutually assured destruction' relied on the "**safety valve**" of **human hesitation**, intuition, and moral pause (e.g., the **1962 Cuban Missile Crisis** or the **1983 Soviet false alarm**).
 - AI battle management systems compress decision times from hours to seconds, completely eliminating this human buffer.
- **Algorithmic Failure Modes:** **Deep neural networks** are susceptible to "**hallucinations**" and "**data poisoning**."
 - In a high-stakes geopolitical crisis, an AI might misinterpret a corrupted image or a routine network ping as an incoming missile, triggering an automated, catastrophic retaliation before humans can intervene.
- **Collapse of Global Security Infrastructure:** Foundational **arms control treaties** (**Open Skies** , **New START**) are failing.
 - This vacuum creates a dangerous security dilemma where paranoid state actors **automate their defenses simply to match the perceived algorithmic speed of their adversaries**.
- **Real-World Triggers (The Iran Scenario):** In contested environments like the **Iranian nuclear program** , where diplomatic buffers have broken down, states increasingly use AI to monitor facilities.
 - A localized digital intrusion or physical strike could be misinterpreted by an automated defense protocol, launching a disproportionate missile response before any human communication occurs.

What are "Convergent Perils" in AI?

- **Convergent Peril:** A **convergent peril** refers to a scenario where multiple distinct risks do not just exist parallelly but **interact**, amplify each other, and converge to create a massive systemic threat.
 - In the context of AI, it represents the deadly intersection of **algorithmic bias**, **loss of human accountability**, **hyper-automation**, and **ethical abdication** . When humanity outsources its moral compass to machines, these individual tech flaws converge into a civilizational crisis.

Concerns Regarding Outsourcing Ethics to AI

- **Erosion of Human Moral Agency:** Ethics is an inherently human exercise. It requires humans to struggle with dilemmas, exercise empathy, and take responsibility.
 - By outsourcing these decisions, humans suffer a "moral deskilling", losing the capacity for ethical reasoning.
 - Luminaries argue that an algorithm cannot *feel* the weight of a decision, stripping the process of its underlying humanity.
- **The "Value Alignment" Problem:** AI models are optimized for efficiency and mathematical outcomes, typically leaning towards **Utilitarianism** (the greatest good for the greatest number).
 - However, human justice heavily relies on **Deontological ethics** (duty, fairness, and individual rights).
 - An AI might ethically justify sacrificing a minority right to maximize a majority outcome—a blatant violation of human rights.
- **Algorithmic Bias and Amplified Discrimination:** AI learns from historical datasets. Society's historical prejudices (caste, race, gender) are embedded in this data.
 - When AI takes over, it institutionalizes these biases under the guise of "objective mathematics," making systemic discrimination harder to challenge.
- **The "Black Box" and Accountability Void:** Advanced Deep Learning models operate as "Black Boxes" even though their creators cannot fully explain how the AI arrived at a specific decision.
 - If an AI denies a deserving citizen a liver transplant or wrongly identifies someone as a criminal, who is held morally and legally culpable? The developer, the user, or the machine? This creates a massive vacuum in accountability.
- **Contextual Blindness:** Human judges, doctors, and officers apply **mercy, equity, and contextual nuance**. AI lacks emotional intelligence and situational awareness. It cannot bend a rigid rule to accommodate a unique, tragic human circumstance.

Global AI Ethics Landscape

- **EU Artificial Intelligence Act, 2024:** World's first comprehensive AI law adopting a **risk-based approach**, banning **unacceptable-risk AI** (e.g., social scoring) and imposing strict obligations on **high-risk AI systems**.
- **Bletchley Park Declaration (2023):** Signed by **28 countries, including India**, recognising risks posed by **frontier AI** and promoting international cooperation on AI safety.
- **UNESCO Recommendation on the Ethics of AI (2021):** First global framework promoting **human dignity, transparency, accountability, human rights, and sustainability** in AI.
- **Global Partnership on Artificial Intelligence (GPAI):** Multi-stakeholder initiative promoting **responsible, inclusive, and human-centric AI**; **India is a founding member** and hosted the [GPAI Summit \(2023\)](#).

India's AI Governance Framework

- **NITI Aayog's National Strategy for AI (2018) - "AI for All":** Introduced the vision of **"AI for All"** for inclusive and socially beneficial AI.

- Advocates **responsible AI** based on principles of **safety, inclusivity, privacy, transparency, fairness, and accountability**.
- **IndiaAI Mission (2024):** Promotes indigenous AI ecosystem through computing infrastructure, datasets, startups, skilling, and innovation.
 - Includes a **"Safe and Trusted AI"** pillar to ensure ethical AI development and deployment.
- **India AI Governance Guidelines (Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY)):** Adopt a **principle-based, techno-legal framework** that balances **innovation with safeguards** and is anchored in the **Seven Sutras** for **trustworthy, human-centric, safe, and responsible AI governance**.



- **Human-in-the-Loop (HITL) Mandate:** Critical decisions involving human life, liberty, or dignity (e.g., judicial, medical, military) must have mandatory human oversight. AI should act as an *augmenter* , not a *decider* .
- **Explainable AI:** Developers must be mandated to build systems where the decision-making process is transparent and auditable by third-party regulators.
- **Ethical Impact Assessments (EIA):** Just like **Environmental Impact Assessments for industries** , AI models should undergo rigorous EIAs before public deployment to check for bias and ethical alignment.
- **Incorporating "Compassion" by Design:** Moving beyond mere mathematical optimization to ensure that AI parameters are explicitly coded to respect fundamental human rights.
- **Global Treaty on LAWS:** A swift, binding UN convention to **ban Lethal Autonomous Weapons Systems (LAWS)** where the decision to kill is outsourced to machines.

Drishti Mains Question:

The growing integration of Artificial Intelligence into strategic military systems has created 'convergent perils' that challenge global peace and human ethics. Discuss.

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

1. What is the Rome Declaration for an Unarmed and Disarming Peace?

It is a global declaration signed by Nobel laureates, AI experts, and religious leaders calling for an international treaty to prohibit autonomous AI systems from accessing or making nuclear launch decisions.

2. What is meant by "Meaningful Human Control" in AI governance?

It requires that **human beings retain the final authority and accountability** over high-risk AI decisions, particularly in military, healthcare, and judicial domains.

3. What are "Convergent Perils" in the context of Artificial Intelligence?

Convergent perils refer to the interaction of multiple AI risks—such as algorithmic bias, automation, lack of accountability, and ethical failures—that together create systemic threats to humanity.

4. What is the objective of India's AI Governance Framework?

It promotes **responsible, trustworthy, and innovation-friendly AI** through principles such as **Trust, Fairness, Accountability, Transparency, Safety, and Sustainability** , while ensuring meaningful human oversight.

5. Why is Explainable AI important for responsible AI governance?

Explainable AI enhances **transparency, accountability, and public trust** by enabling users and regulators to understand and audit AI-driven decisions, especially in high-risk applications.

[Watch Video on YouTube: [▶ https://www.youtube.com/embed/kdEN7OAAjOc](https://www.youtube.com/embed/kdEN7OAAjOc)]

UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year Question (PYQ)

Prelims:

Q. With the present state of development, Artificial Intelligence can effectively do which of the following? (2020)

1. Bring down electricity consumption in industrial units
2. Create meaningful short stories and songs
3. Disease diagnosis
4. Text-to-Speech Conversion
5. Wireless transmission of electrical energy

Select the correct answer using the code given below:

- (a) 1, 2, 3 and 5 only
- (b) 1, 3 and 4 only
- (c) 2, 4 and 5 only
- (d) 1, 2, 3, 4 and 5

Ans: (b)

Mains:

Q. Introduce the concept of Artificial Intelligence (AI). How does AI help clinical diagnosis? Do you perceive any threat to privacy of the individual in the use of AI in healthcare? (2023)

Q. Impact of digital technology as a reliable source of input for rational decision making is an issue. Critically evaluate with suitable examples. (2021)

Amrit Bharat Station Scheme



Source: PIB

Why in News?

Recently, the Prime Minister inaugurated **75 redeveloped railway stations across 20 States** under the **Amrit Bharat Station Scheme**, as part of efforts to modernise railway infrastructure and transform stations into passenger-centric transit hubs.

- This is the **second major nationwide dedication** of redeveloped stations under the scheme. Earlier, on **22 May 2025** , the Prime Minister dedicated **103 redeveloped Amrit Bharat Stations across 18 States and Union Territories** .

What is the Amrit Bharat Station Scheme?

- **About:** The **Amrit Bharat Station Scheme (ABSS)** , introduced by the **Ministry of Railways in December 2022** , aims to redevelop **1,309 railway stations** into modern integrated transport hubs across India.
 - It follows a **phased, station-specific redevelopment approach** , with plans prepared according to local requirements, passenger footfall, and future growth needs.
 - The scheme focuses on improving passenger experience, integrating regional architecture, enhancing accessibility, and supporting urban development.
- **Key Features:**
 - **Customised & Culturally Integrated Redevelopment:** Stations are redeveloped with location-specific designs combining modern facilities with local heritage, culture, and architectural themes.
 - **Examples:**

Design Inspirations by City



Ahmedabad

Inspired by
Modhera Sun Temple



Dwarka

Inspired by
Dwarkadhish Temple



Kumbakonam

Reflects
Chola architecture



Gurugram

Based on
modern urban design



- **Passenger Amenities & Modern Facilities:** Provides improved entry and exit points, modern waiting areas, covered platforms, clean restrooms, lifts, escalators, free Wi-Fi, executive lounges, business areas, food courts, kiosks, and enhanced passenger information systems.
 - Includes aesthetically designed façades, landscaping, roof plazas, improved lighting, parking facilities, and better circulation areas.
- **Inclusive & Accessible Design:** Aligned with the [Accessible India Campaign \(Sugamya Bharat Abhiyan\)](#), the scheme ensures facilities for **Divyangjan and passengers with reduced mobility** through ramps, accessible parking, low-height counters, Braille signage, tactile pathways, accessible toilets, and lift-equipped subways/foot overbridges.
- **Local Economic Promotion (One Station One Product):** Promotes indigenous and regional products by providing kiosks and outlets at railway stations for local artisans, weavers, tribal communities, handicrafts, handlooms, and region-specific food products.
- **Urban Connectivity & Sustainability:** Develops stations as **multimodal urban centres** by integrating railways with bus and metro networks and connecting both sides of cities through improved station planning.
 - Incorporates eco-friendly measures such as green spaces, sustainable infrastructure, and improved

environmental planning.

- **Significance:** The scheme aims to transform railway stations from mere transit points into **vibrant city centres** by improving passenger convenience, promoting local economies, preserving regional identity, and creating future-ready transport infrastructure.



Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

1. What is the Amrit Bharat Station Scheme?

The Amrit Bharat Station Scheme is a railway station redevelopment programme launched by the Ministry of Railways in December 2022 to transform railway stations into modern, integrated and passenger-friendly transport hubs.

2. How many railway stations are covered under the scheme?

The scheme aims to redevelop 1,309 railway stations across India.

3. Why was the scheme recently in the news?

The Prime Minister inaugurated 75 redeveloped railway stations across 20 States under the scheme.

4. Was this the first nationwide inauguration under the scheme?

No. It was the second major nationwide dedication. Earlier, 103 redeveloped stations across 18 States and Union Territories were inaugurated on 22 May 2025.

5. What was the total cost of redeveloping the 75 stations?

The 75 stations were redeveloped at a combined cost of approximately ₹1,570 crore.

[Watch Video on YouTube:

▶ https://www.youtube.com/embed/fliYAwzv_Ls

]

UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year Questions

Prelims

Q. Which one of the following pairs is not correctly matched? [2006]

Railway Zone - Headquarters

- a) North Eastern Railway – Gorakhpur
- b) South Eastern Railway – Bhubaneswar
- c) Eastern Railway- Kolkata
- d) South East Central Railway – Bilaspur

Ans: (b)

Mains

Q. The setting up of a Rail Tariff Authority to regulate fares will subject the cash strapped Indian Railways to demand subsidy for the obligation to operate non-profitable routes and services. Taking into account the experience in the power sector, discuss if the proposed reform is expected to benefit the consumers, the Indian Railways or the private container operators. **(2014)**

President's State Visit to Romania



Source: PIB

President **Droupadi Murmu** visited **Romania** on the final leg of her State Visits to **Moldova, North Macedonia, and Romania** , marking the **first State Visit by an Indian President to Romania in nearly three decades** .

- India and Romania reaffirmed their **70-year partnership** and agreed to deepen cooperation in **trade, investment, and resilient supply chains** , with a target to **double bilateral trade within three years** .
 - India enjoys a **trade surplus** with Romania. In **FY 2024-25** , **Romania accounted for 0.24% of India's exports** and was India's **56 th largest export destination** .
 - Key Indian exports include **petroleum products, engineering goods, and pharmaceuticals** , while imports comprise **machinery, vegetable oils, and iron & steel** .
- **Importance of India-EU FTA:** India highlighted that **Romania is an important partner within the European Union** and emphasized that the **India-EU Free Trade Agreement (FTA)** would create significant opportunities for **industries and skilled professionals** .
- **Strengthening Education & Cultural Ties:** **Three agreements** were signed in the areas of **education, culture, and people-to-people exchanges** , reinforcing the social foundations of bilateral relations.
- **Science & Technology Cooperation:** Both countries agreed to expand **joint Research & Development (R&D)** under the **Programme of Cooperation in Science and Technology** .
- **Promotion of Indian Culture:** An **Indian Studies Chair** will be established at the **University of Bucharest** with the support of the **Indian Council for Cultural Relations (ICCR)** .
- **Capacity Building:** India announced that it will **double training opportunities for Romania** under the **Indian Technical and Economic Cooperation (ITEC) Programme** .
- **India-Romania Year of Innovation:** To commemorate the **80th anniversary of diplomatic relations in 2028** , both countries agreed to celebrate **2028 as the "India-Romania Year of Innovation."**

Romania

- **Location:** Romania is a **South-Eastern European** country bordered by **Ukraine (North), Moldova (East), the Black Sea (South-East), Bulgaria (South), Serbia (South-West), and Hungary (North-West)** . Its capital is **Bucharest** .
- **Political Profile:** Romania is a **democratic republic** , a member of the **European Union (EU)**, **NATO**.
- **Physical Features:** The country has a **symmetrical relief** , with nearly **one-third mountains, one-third hills, and one-third plains** . Major geographical features include the **Carpathian Mountains** , **Transylvanian Basin** , **Danube Delta (UNESCO World Heritage Site)** , and fertile **Chernozem plains** .
- **Economy:** Romania is a **high-income economy** . It is among the **fastest-growing economies in the European Union** .

- **Strategic Significance:** Located on the **Black Sea** , Romania hosts the **Port of Constanța** , a major gateway for **Europe-Asia trade** . It serves as an important partner for India in sectors such as **IT, pharmaceuticals, automobiles, renewable energy** , and in strengthening **India-EU economic cooperation** .



Read more: [Romania and Bulgaria Join Schengen Zone](#)

Brazil's Amazon Records Historic Low in Forest Fires



Source:TH

Forest fires in **Brazil's Amazon** declined to their **lowest level since records began in 1985** , marking a sharp recovery from the severe fire season of **2024** and highlighting progress in forest conservation.

- **Reasons for Decline:** A **delayed rainy season** , **reduced deforestation** , and greater community vigilance prevented the spread of fires and reduced combustible forest fuel.
- **Human-Induced Fires:** Most fires in **2024** were **man-made** , linked to **agricultural land clearing, deforestation, and illegal mining** .
- **Climate Risk:** Scientists warned that a possible **Super El Niño** could bring an extended dry season, increasing the likelihood of future forest fires.

Amazon Rainforest

- **Location & Extent:** The Amazon Rainforest, the world's largest tropical rainforest, covers about **6 million sq. km** across **nine South American territories** , with nearly **60% located in Brazil** .
 - It spans the **Amazon River Basin** , the **world's largest river basin** .
- **Natural Boundaries:** It is bounded by the **Guiana Highlands (North)**, **Andes Mountains (West)**, **Brazilian Plateau (South)**, and the **Atlantic Ocean (East)** .
- **Climate:** Characterized by **high rainfall, high humidity, and uniformly warm temperatures** , supporting a dense evergreen rainforest ecosystem.
- **Biodiversity Hotspot:** The Amazon hosts nearly **10% of the world's known wildlife species** , making it one of the planet's richest centres of biodiversity.
- **Rich Flora & Fauna:** Notable flora include **Brazil nut, rubber, mahogany, cedar, and rosewood** , while fauna include the **jaguar, capybara, tapir, sloth, anaconda, caiman, toucan, and macaw** .
- **Protected Areas:** Important protected regions include **Yasuni National Park (Ecuador)**, **Jau National Park, Tumucumaque National Park, Pico da Neblina National Park (Brazil)**, **Manu National Park and Pacaya-Samiria National Reserve (Peru)**, and **Amacayacu National Natural Park (Colombia)**.
- **Global Importance:** Often called the "**Lungs of the Earth**," the Amazon functions as a major **carbon sink** , helping regulate the global climate and supporting ecological balance.
- **Amazon River:** Originating in the **Peruvian Andes** , the **Amazon River** is the **world's largest river by discharge** and the **second-longest river after the Nile** . Major tributaries include the **Rio Negro, Madeira, and Xingu** .



Read more: [Amazon Rainforest](#)

Supreme Court Clarifies Scope of Special Intensive Revision



Source: TH

Recently, the **Supreme Court** observed that the **Special Intensive Revision (SIR) process** is limited to electoral purposes and cannot be used for other objectives, including determining citizenship or affecting access to welfare benefits.

- The Court was hearing a petition alleging that the **West Bengal government** was using SIR data to remove names from welfare schemes such as **food security programmes, women's welfare schemes, and Backward Caste certifications**.
- The Court observed that, as per its earlier judgment in the **2025 Bihar SIR case**, SIR outcomes cannot be used for any purpose other than elections. The **Election Commission** must refer citizenship-related issues to the government for adjudication under the **Citizenship Act, 1955**.

Special Intensive Revision

- **SIR:** The SIR is a comprehensive exercise conducted under the supervision of the **Chief Election Commissioner** to update and purify electoral rolls.
- **Legal Basis:** The SIR is anchored in **Article 324 of the Indian Constitution**, which grants the ECI superintendence over elections, and **Section 21(3) of the Representation of the People Act (RPA), 1950**, which specifically empowers the commission to order a special revision.
- **Objective:** Its primary objective is to **remove duplicate, deceased, shifted, and ineligible voters, including "ghost voters,"** to ensure that electoral rolls accurately reflect the **eligible voting population and uphold the democratic principle of "one person, one vote."**
- **Background:** The Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls has been conducted **eight times between 1951 and 2004**, with the last SIR carried out during 2002–2004, over two decades ago.

Read more: [Special Intensive Revision of Electoral Rolls](#)